



DEPARTMENT OF THE NAVY

OUTLYING LANDING FIELD
SAN NICOLAS ISLAND
NAVAL AIR STATION
POINT MUGU, CALIFORNIA 93042

LEGEND OF SAN NICOLAS ISLAND:

THE ABANDONED WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS

By 1835, raiding otter hunters and white man's diseases had reduced the number of Indians on San Nicolas Island from fifteen-hundred to eighteen or twenty, and the Franciscan mission fathers decided to remove the last of them to the mainland, where their pagan souls could be properly saved. The fathers arranged with Charles Hubbard, captain of a small schooner, to bring the Indians to San Pedro. His vessel had been built at Santa Barbara by a Mexican named Joaquin Gomez. He was apparently not too well pleased with his handiwork for she was christened Peor es Nada, "Better than Nothing".

When Captain Hubbard and the Peor es Nada reached the island, he rounded up the Indians and told them as well as he could what the mission fathers had proposed. He assured them that on the mainland they would no longer be subjected to mistreatment by the brutal hunters and that there would be plenty to eat and an easier life.

As the Indians piled their poor belongings into the Peor es Nada, the sky suddenly became gray with clouds and strong winds threatened to hurl the boat against the rocky shore of the island. Captain Hubbard made haste to leave. But one of the Indian women suddenly discovered that her child had not been brought aboard the boat, and she cried out that she had to go back for the baby. Leaping into the water, she swam ashore. Finally it was impossible for Captain Hubbard to wait any longer, and the Peor es Nada set sail across the choppy channel, leaving the Indian woman and her child alone on the island.

When he reached the mainland, Captain Hubbard described the unfortunate occurrence on San Nicolas Island. He could not return immediately because he had a commitment to carry a group of otter hunters led by George Nidever to Santa Rosa Island and then up the coast to San Francisco, but he hoped to go back to the island soon after his return from the Bay Area. Neither he nor the Peor es Nada had the opportunity, however, for less than a month after the woman was abandoned, the boat, with Captain Hubbard aboard, sank in San Francisco Bay.

For fifteen years no one sought to find the Indian. Although the story was often told, few believed that she or her child could have survived alone for very long. San Nicolas was known to be overrun with packs of vicious wild dogs. It had been difficult enough for the last small Indian band on the island to defend themselves from the animals, and those on the mainland considered it impossible for a young woman alone.

In 1850, George Nidever and a friend named Thomas Jefferies sailed with a crew of Indians to San Nicolas. Their purpose was twofold: to hunt otter and, if at all possible, to find the remains of the Indian woman. For six weeks they stripped otter and seal hides, salted the skins, and stowed them in the boat, but they saw no sign of the Indian. Then one night a crewman who had been on a hike around the island returned to the camp flushed with excitement. He told of seeing a figure running in the distance and of trying in vain to catch up. It did not seem possible, but perhaps it was the lost woman. The men failed to learn the answer.

Three years and several trips later, on another otter hunting excursion to the island, Nidever and a companion, Carl Detman, spotted a basket containing a robe made of birds' plumage. Now Nidever was sure. Incredible as it seems, the Indian woman who swam back to the island eighteen years earlier to find her lost child was still on San Nicolas Island and was alive.

Nidever immediately abandoned his hunt for otter and ordered his men to join him in searching the island canyon by canyon, cave by cave, until the woman was found. It was Detman who made the discovery. He traced footprints to a grass shelter on one of the Island's peaks. Here, the woman, dressed in cormorant feathers, was seated in her hide-away watching Nidever's party searching the beach below for her. She appeared to be in excellent physical condition. There was a large supply of food in her grass hut, a pack of dogs trained to answer her commands was at her side, and two pet ravens were perched nearby.

Although she had been surprised by Detman and despite the fact that he was the first person she had seen in eighteen years, she accepted his presence calmly. Detman summoned Nidever and the entire party gathered around. She told them the story of her years on the island, not in words, for no one could understand her language, but by signs she explained how she had found her child dead, killed by wild dogs, when she swam to the island the day the Peor es Nada left without her.

She knew every inch of the island, had walked its length and breadth through the years with her dogs at her side. She never lacked for food, but lived on birds, fish, abalone, and seal blubber. Water was easy to obtain from the many springs. Although her life was lonely, she came in time to accept it and fled in fear from visitors.

When Nidever returned to the mainland he took the Indian woman to his Santa Barbara home where his wife cared for her. The story of her discovery spread, and the curious came from miles to see the strange "wild" woman, who, in reality, was quiet and shy, amazingly attractive in spite of her ordeal.

But there was one immediate problem. No one could be found who spoke the woman's language. Mission fathers searched in vain for one of the Indians taken from the Island in 1835. Ultimately, civilization proved to be a greater challenge to her than life alone on San Nicolas, and she began to fail rapidly. Soon she became too weak to walk. On her death bed, one of the fathers from the Santa Barbara mission baptised her, giving her the name of Juana Maria. Within three months of her discovery, the last of the Channel Island Indians was dead, and with her their centuries-old culture.

Juana Maria was buried in the graveyard of Mission Santa Barbara. A plaque placed in 1928 is inscribed:

JUANA MARIA
INDIAN WOMAN ABANDONED ON
SAN NICOLAS ISLAND EIGHTEEN YEARS
FOUND AND BROUGHT TO
SANTA BARBARA
BY CAPTAIN GEORGE NIDEVER
IN 1853